

Rebel without a cause!

If you happened to walk past Dmart in the past few weeks, you may have noticed a sign that says 'Do not leave garbage here. Will be punished according to law'. You may then have seen that most of the garbage in that area is around this notice. This begs the question, why do we purposely ignore warnings? or, why do people rebel?

When we look at APU, we can find such examples easily. Why do we break into the Hampi terrace when we are specifically told not to? Or why do we feel like sneaking into the library past closing time? To understand the psychology behind our rebellious nature, I approached a SAS faculty at our university.

How important is your freedom to you, more importantly, how would you react if this very freedom was threatened by someone are questions that drive and affect what is known as 'reactance' (an inherited trait). The professor explained that any such strongly worded notice, or warning, threatens your autonomy and directly affects how you react to a situation. Or simply, you are likely to have a heightened reaction, if your freedom of choice is threatened. We see this everyday on our floor bathrooms. It seems obvious that you should leave the bathroom clean after use, so then why are cubicles so dirty most of the time? There is no accountability while using common bathrooms. Those who value their freedom more will react in a negative way when the message to convey bathroom cleanliness uses strong wordings. Using softer language, like the funny quotes in the Hampi bathrooms which ask us to clean up, stick with us and might be more effective.

Words like 'should' and 'must', or future threats and warnings are a part of 'high controlling language'. Words like 'please' or 'advise you to' may work better with people at large. Another effective thing is the presence of a 'social actor', someone who is voicing the warning and someone people can interact with. People littered because at the end of the day no one can hold them accountable. There was no camera in the vicinity, and the notice wasn't issued by a recognizable person. Similarly, people leave Hampi bathrooms dirty, because no one can hold them accountable. Here, the hygiene aspect also comes into play. For those with a higher conformity to maintain hygiene, this tendency overpowers the freedom given. We hence pose the question, would you do the same at home? When does one ignore their values on sanitation? Is rebelling worth it, especially when you will be using the same bathroom again?

Another important factor that influences someone's reaction is 'guilt'. Warnings with strong language taps into a person's guilt, which may lead to a reaction just for the sake of defiance. This may seem counterintuitive, after all, if you feel guilty about something, wouldn't you (ideally) not repeat it again? The effect of guilt on decisions is still not very clear, with different studies giving contradictory results. But some research suggests that if a message taps a person's moral compass, it may lead to a negative reaction due to defensiveness. Hence, trying too hard to control someone's behaviour might just backfire.

A lot of factors are at play behind what influences people's actions and in particular, reactions. Thus persuading them to follow certain rules requires very carefully thought out messages. Threatening statements have not worked and will probably not lead to change any time soon. People will continue to defy and rebel, it is a part of our very nature to do so.